

The Countdown

The reform project that went wrong

■ The state had to withdraw the Rs 1,000-crore Kolkata IT Links project with information technology giants Wipro and Infosys after the Vedic Village incident on August 23.

■ In June, Maoists took control of Lalgarh in West Midnapore district and turned it into a fortress after alleged police brutality over an assassination attempt on the chief minister.

■ Putting paid to the chief minister's dream of 40,000 jobs and hopes of boosting the state's sunrise sector, DLF shelved its Rs 40,000-crore Dankuni township project and the Rs 700-crore DLF SEZ at Rajarhat earlier this year, citing land issues.

■ The Tata pullout last October from Singur and Nandigram, following protests and police firing over land acquisition was one of the first nails in the CPI(M)'s coffin.

■ In 2007, the West Bengal Government decided to allow the Salim Group to set up a chemical hub at Nandigram under the SEZ policy. Local opposition to the project led to clashes with the police that left 14 villagers dead and the project buried forever.

On September 9, home secretary Ardhendu Sen announced that there was no case against Arabul. "If nothing has been proved against him, how can he be arrested?" said Sen, uttering in the same breath that no CPI(M) minister or bigwig has been found guilty as yet. So, everybody except hapless Vedic Village owner Modi

seems innocent. Whispers in police circles, however, indicate otherwise. Apparently Gaffar's list could spell doom for both the CPI(M) and the Trinamool. Unless, of course, some other type of deal ensures that the unsavoury stuff remains within the confines of the interrogation room. Khuday remains untraceable.

The Vedic Village incident shows that the Government has no control over the rural leadership and that panchayat governance has gone for a toss. Till the other day, before Bhattacharya's favourite IT department stopped the infotech township project in which 20,000 jobs had been proposed with an initial investment of Rs 1,000 crore, the man in the eye of the storm was Land Reforms Minister Abdur Rejjak Mollah. He held a press conference shortly after his name came up for having broken land ceiling laws to facilitate flow of funds to the Village owners. It was quite obvious at that time that the CPI(M) show of unity was cracking. While the Left Front itself has fought many internecine battles, never has the CPI(M) been at war with itself. But the minister prefaced his press conference with a bombshell of a remark saying, "I am ready with all the arms." The arms proved to be few and hardly of any consequence as he could do little to clear his role in the scam

the court case outside with compensation, it would have dragged on while the Village promoters would have continued with mischief... what I did was to gather funds for the Government, which would have never come if the case had dragged on," said Mollah. Nobody gave his version any credence because a matter of 44 acres and a Rs 25-crore loss to the exchequer suddenly seemed a relatively small act of stubbornness.

Bhattacharya immediately knew that this was beyond damage: it was utter destruction. His sunrise industry of information technology with a major proposed hub at Rajarhat suddenly seemed to dim overnight as ministers Deb and Mollah fought over who gave which orders and party chief Biman Bose flew to the Politburo meeting in Delhi without his chief minister (for the second time in succession, raising further eyebrows) and made loud noises of "correction" within the party. With Bhattacharya's Destination Bengal showpiece as well as his Do It Now slogan falling flat, there is also an open hunt in the party for deputy chief minister. All point to his redundancy within the party and that he wants to pull out of the dogmatic matrix of Marxism.

All this while, arch enemy Banerjee kept quiet over an incident which anybody would have thought was God's gift

“What I did was in the state's interest, which would have suffered if the case had dragged on.”



ABDUR REJIAK MOLLAH, Land Reforms Minister

“The ruling CPI(M) has made matters so murky for itself that it will hardly find the ground beneath its feet.”



PARTHA CHATTERJEE, Trinamool Leader

which got bigger by the minute. Flaunting files, all that Mollah could say was that he had acted in the state Government's "interest". This, when he gave away 44 acres of vested government land above the ceiling limit for almost free at Rs 97 lakh against the official buying rate of Rs 25 crore. "If I had gone in for litigation and not settled

for her. Perhaps she was practising restraint for the coming years as the next chief minister. Leader of Opposition in the Assembly Partha Chatterjee explained it away in simple terms which would have raised some hopes if only they were just about a true assessment. "Why should we comment and why lead a movement when the facts are